

Shikaripura in Shimoga district. It is a titanic battle and Yeddyurappa just cannot afford to lose in a region where Bangarappa is equally strong. Bangarappa has vacated the Sorab seat for his son Madhu.

Interestingly, more than 20 brothers are pitched in the poll fray this time. In Bellary, Karunakara and Somashekara are fighting for the BJP. The Jharkoli brothers are divided—Ramesh is with the Congress, Bhimish is taking on the fight from Gokak on a BJP ticket and Balachandran is in the JD(s) but the most famous sibling rivalry is between Bangarappa's sons Kumar (Congress) and Madhu (SP). Bangarappa had quit the BJP in 2005 and re-entered the Lok Sabha on an SP ticket. Bellary's most famous BJP brothers—Janardhan, Karunakara and Somashekara—are also mining barons of the district and have single-handedly eliminated the hold of the Congress in the district.

The biggest poll issues that will determine the electoral fortunes of parties are again the basic populist issues, the *roti, kapda aur makaan* variety. The Congress's massive loan waiver is a welcome sign for farmers. The inflation-hit Congress is also embarking on its own brand of sop opera—its manifesto promises free colour TVs, rice at Rs 2 per kg, waiver of all pending loans under Ashraya and Awaz Yojana schemes and extension of Yeshaswini health insurance to families below the poverty line. Also on offer is a monthly stipend of Rs 1,200 for all those who have cleared Class X. The BJP, with a clear view of reaching out to farmers, has also promised a slew of freebies including free power supply, irrigation pump sets and rice at Rs 2 per kg for the poor. JD(s) wants to give away houses to the poor apart from pro-farmer policies.

Thanks to strict policies enforced by EC officials, candidates are also showing off their creativity in wooing voters; from distributing insurance certificates to women to lending heavy earth-moving equipment to farmers for levelling their lands. A candidate in Mysore distributed school notebooks bearing his photo hoping to reach out to parents. Another distributed rice bags to slum dwellers, claiming it was part of a religious charity. Posters and



KITH AND KIN:
(Clockwise from left)
Kumaraswamy and
Revanna, Nichani
and the Bangarappa
brothers



Not all family ties are cordial. While **GOWDA'S** offsprings fight hand-in-hand, **BANGARAPPA'S** sons are in different parties taking on each other

banners are conspicuous by their absence. Chief Election Commissioner N. Gopalaswami told leaders at a meeting in Bangalore to desist from using plastic in any form for electioneering. The poll panel is also invoking the provisions of the Karnataka Open Places (Prevention of Disfigurement) Act, 1981, to ban political parties from putting up banners, buntings and cutouts of candidates in public places.

With candidates camouflaging their expenses—the EC has restricted the poll budget to Rs 10 lakh per

candidate—this will be one of the most creative electoral campaigns ever. The EC has already seized 3,000 watches in Chikkaballapur, a few truck loads of tiles meant for roofing in coastal areas and about 1,100 saris in Ramanagaram, Kumaraswamy's newly carved district.

Karnataka will be the first state in the country to go to the polls under the changed electoral map that followed the delimitation exercise. The results, however, are likely to show that the electoral map has hardly changed. ■